IT TAKES A VILLAGE, BUT....

Information overload is plaguing new parents with anxiety every time there is a spit-up. Doctors advise moderation



MORE PREGNANCIES HAPPEN IN INSTITUTIONS

- **90.6% of births now take place in health institutions** *(NFHS-6, 2023-24)*
- **27.2% of births happen by C-section, the rate rising to 40.5% in urban India and 54.1% in private hospitals**
- **This is far above the WHO-recommended rate of 10-15% for a population, above which maternal/newborn survival doesn't improve**



BUT URBAN PARENTS ARE OVERDOING TESTS

- **Repeated growth scans, Doppler ultrasounds and non-essential genetic tests**
- **Elective inductions, planned Caesarean deliveries and 3D/4D 'keepsake' scans**



AND A LUXURY MARKET IS EMERGING

- **Premium maternity suites for delivery and recovery**
  Cost: ₹15,000-60,000 per day
- **Antenatal wellness programmes with yoga, Lamaze and counselling**
  Cost: ₹5,000-20,000
- **Lactation consultations**
  Cost: ₹1,500-5,000 per session
- **Storing newborn stem cells for future use**
  Cost: ₹70,000-2 lakh
- **Major providers in India include Apollo Cradle, Cloudnine Hospitals, Motherhood Hospitals, Rainbow Children's Hospital, Fortis La Femme and Cocoon Hospital**

of respiratory tract infections, asthma, allergic rhinitis, atopic dermatitis and childhood obesity than those born vaginally, although the authors stressed these were associations and not proof of cause and effect. "We are seeing more pregnancies at an advanced maternal age, a higher prevalence of gestational diabetes and hypertension, and more pregnancies conceived through assisted reproductive techniques. These situations often make Caesarean delivery the safer option," says Dr Sharma. "Obstetricians point out that even younger women are increasingly presenting with high blood pressure and diabetes during pregnancy, contributing to the rise in medically indicated Caesarean births," says Dr Anita Gupta, senior director of gynaecology at Fortis La Femme, Delhi. The bottom line, cautions Dr Sharma, is that "the decision to perform a Caesarean should always be guided by clinical indications and individual patient needs rather than convenience or preference alone".

NO ANTIDOTE TO ANXIETY?

Unfortunately, convenience often drives the decision. Samira Batra, a 34-year-old Delhi professional who had a planned C-section for her first child says she never considered labour because she was terrified of pain. Fear of childbirth—known medically as tokophobia—is also being recognised globally as an important reason why women request elective C-sections, something a 2021 systematic review in *BMC Pregnancy and Childbirth* corroborated. Another such review in the *Journal of Affective Disorders* in 2022 found an association between pregnancy-related anxiety and higher rates of medical interventions during childbirth, including operative deliveries.

The same desire for reassurance is changing the way pregnancy is monitored. Obstetricians say many low-risk women now seek repeated growth scans, multiple Doppler ultrasounds and non-indicated tests despite normal pregnancies. While ultrasound itself is safe when medically indicated, experts caution that unnecessary scanning can increase anxiety rather than reduce it. "It isn't simply that parents are overthinking, they are dealing with information overload. Urban parenting today comes with constant pressure to monitor sleep, feeding and developmental milestones, while parenting apps and social media expose families to conflicting advice. After a few sleepless nights, everything feels urgent," says Gopinath. Every additional scan, say doctors, can uncover borderline findings that trigger further testing, consultations and unnecessary stress without improving outcomes. "If you are raising a baby in a city without family support, you are dealing with a crying baby at 3 am and Google at the same time. No one is there to tell you what is normal. Every spit-up, every 15-45-minute nap and every missed milestone begins to feel like something that needs research. That is what information overload does to parents."

DOCTORS FIND NOTHING WRONG WITH AN INFORMED PARENT. THE WORRIES BEGIN WHEN CONVENIENCE TRUMPS CLINICAL NEED

The biggest gap in modern motherhood may no longer be professional medical care, but there is still much to be done with regards to appropriate education of parents, trusting medical advice and an ecosystem that nurtures pregnancies without fuelling anxiety. ■